



Hooray for Beans!

Beans have been around since ancient times. Many varieties have been part of the growth and survival of cultures around the world. Inexpensive, nutritious, filling, delicious, and available in a wonderful variety of colors, the positive attributes of beans have been a well-kept secret!

Gas may initially be a problem when switching to a higher-fiber diet. However, your body will adjust to your diet over time. Here are some tips to ease problems with gas associated with eating beans:

-  People who eat beans regularly have little or no trouble digesting them, so start with smaller servings and work up to larger and more frequent servings. If you are replacing a huge steak with an equally huge serving of beans, it pays to realize that you'll still get plenty of protein and good overall nutrition with smaller servings. Work up to 1-2 cups of beans per day.
-  Smaller beans are easier to digest for some people, so try red and green lentils, black beans, and black-eyed peas, and work your way up to pinto, kidney, and all the other types of beans. Search out new varieties—there are dozens!
-  To prepare dried beans, soak for at least eight hours, drain them, and then cook them in fresh water. The indigestible sugars leach into the soak water and are rinsed away. It may also help to add a pinch of baking soda to the soaking water.
-  Make sure the beans are thoroughly cooked—no “al dente” beans! Cook beans as long as possible. Heat helps to make them more digestible.
-  Cook beans with epazote, a pungent wild herb commonly used in Mexican and Caribbean cuisine. Epazote is a carminative—meaning that it breaks down some of the complex sugars in beans, which helps reduce the production of gas.
-  Kombu, a sea vegetable, added to both the soak water and cook water tends to make the beans more digestible. Dried kombu is sold in the Asian section of many grocery stores.
-  Soaked and cooked beans freeze well, so a large pot can be used to make many meals.
-  Canned beans are the ultimate “fast” food. Drain and gently rinse canned beans. This also decreases the amount of salt in some brands.

Adapted from NutritionMD.org and *Breaking the Food Seduction: The Hidden Reasons Behind Food Cravings and 7 Steps to End Them Naturally* by Neal Barnard, M.D. For hundreds of low-fat bean recipes, visit www.NutritionMD.org and www.drmcDougall.com.